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— Tantravārttika, 50 (Chapter 20). Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

The Tantravārttika, a commentary on the Mimamsa Sūtras, begins by addressing the nature of language and its inherent imperfections. It speaks of the futility of seeking absolute order and consistency in everyday language. The scripture points out that ordinary language, laden with contradictions and inconsistencies ("vigāna-bhuyisthaḥ viruddhaḥ"), lacks a firm foundation ("mūla-varjitaḥ") and ultimately proves unfruitful ("niṣphalaḥ"). Because of this inherent disorder, the governance ("vyavasthānam") of words cannot effectively arise solely from grammatical rules ("nānushaṇāt").

The text emphasizes the importance of Vedic study ("svadhyaya-adhyayanam") and its proper application in rituals ("tat-prayogash cha karmasu"). Outside this sacred domain, in the realm of everyday speech ("shesha-shabda-prayogeshu"), strict regulation proves impractical. The Tantravārttika uses the example of words like "gavi," "goni," and others, which all denote "cow-ness" ("gotvasya vachakah"). These diverse words are accepted because elders have used them, similar to how we accept words like "gaur" or "ustra" (cow/camel). This highlights that common usage, rooted in tradition and practical understanding, takes precedence over rigid grammatical constraints outside the Vedic context.

Applying this to modern life, you can see how the pursuit of absolute perfection in communication often leads to frustration. The *Tantravārttika* reminds you that language is a living, evolving entity. It's more important to focus on clear communication and mutual understanding than to be bogged down in pedantic rules. Just as the elders accepted various words for "cow," we must be open to the diverse ways people express themselves, focusing on the essence of their message rather than nitpicking their grammar. Embrace the fluidity and flexibility of language, recognizing that its true purpose is to connect us, not to divide us with rigid structures. In your own life, consider how you might release the need for perfection in your speech and writing, prioritizing connection and clarity instead.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

Can you identify areas in your life where you are overly critical of language, and how might you shift your focus to the underlying meaning and intention?